Unit 6 — Media Literacy, Advanced

Track E · Klasse 11 · Niveau E (Basisfach / Leistungsfach)

Learning objectives I

- *I can read a long-form journalistic piece and identify the writer's framing, sourcing pattern, and one disclosed limitation.*
- *I can use academic critique vocabulary (*frame, framing effect, sourcing, attribution, anonymisation, conflict of interest*).*
- *I can write a 300-word media-criticism essay.*

Lead-in I

Maja read a 1,200-word piece by an English-language outlet on a contested local protest. She underlined the verbs of attribution. By the end she had counted: *said* 11 times, *insisted* 3, *claimed* 4, *denied* 1, *added* 2. She wrote in the margin: *verbs of attribution are votes*.

Vocabulary I

- frame
- framing effect
- agenda-setting
- sourcing
- anonymous source
- on-the-record
- off-the-record
- attribution verb
- lede
- nut graf
- disclosure
- conflict of interest

Vocabulary I

- false balance
- both-sidesing
- structural balance

Reading I

Reading — *Verbs of Attribution*
Long-form journalism is, mostly, a question of framing and verbs. The frame is what the article treats as the question; everything before the subhead is doing frame work. The verbs of attribution carry, accordingly, more weight than their dictionary definitions suggest. Said is neutral; *claimed* signals doubt; *insisted* signals stubbornness; *added* signals subordination. A reader who counts the verbs already knows half the writer's argument before they reach the conclusion.

Vocabulary — media critique (advanced)
frame, framing effect, agenda-setting, sourcing, anonymous source, on-the-record, off-the-record, attribution verb, lede, nut graf, disclosure, conflict of interest, false balance, both-sidesing,

Reading II

structural balance.

Practise I

Niveau E — controlled

1. Rank attribution verbs by neutrality (most neutral first): *insisted, said, claimed, added, denied*.
2. Match: lede → article opening; nut graf → core-argument paragraph; both-sidesing → false balance.

Niveau E — productive

3. Build 4 sentences using 4 advanced media-critique terms about a long-form article.

Your turn I

Media-criticism essay, 300 words. Pick a long-form article. Identify framing, sourcing, attribution pattern, and one disclosed limitation. Use 5 advanced media-critique terms + 2 hedges.

Sample

The article frames the protest as a question of public order versus expression. This is itself a framing choice; an alternative frame — *housing-rights protest* — would have produced a different piece. Accordingly, the lede privileges police concerns, and the nut graf does not appear until paragraph four. The sourcing pattern is asymmetric: the police source is on-the-record and named; the two protester sources are anonymous, citing fear of professional consequences.

Your turn II

This asymmetry is disclosed in a half-sentence late in the piece, which is a transparent if minimal acknowledgement. The attribution verbs do, however, do most of the covert work. The police source *says* and *adds*; the anonymous protesters *insist* and *claim*. By the end of the article, the careful reader has been voted at — without a single fact having to bend. However, the piece is not, in my view, dishonest. It is conventionally framed in a way that a neighbouring outlet would frame differently. The more useful critique is structural: the routine choice of *public order* as the default frame is not decided by individual writers but by the desk above them. Caution is warranted; readers who count attribution verbs will, in this regard, get more out of long-form than readers who don't. The framing habit, like the verbs, is teachable.

Reflect I

- I can identify framing, sourcing pattern, and one disclosed limitation.
- I can use 5 advanced media-critique terms.
- I can write a 300-word media-criticism essay.

Further reading / listening I

- Reuters Institute Digital News Report.
- Columbia Journalism Review — accessible essays.